

MARRA WONGA · SEVEN SISTERS

Fifteen thousand markings, read in order.

Two ways of reading the same wall — what the study found, and what Iningai law already held.

Over 15,000 petroglyphs and 111 stencils run along 160 metres of shelter wall — animal tracks, lines, grooves, drilled holes, and human feet with six toes. The Iningai name for the place is Marra Wonga. It means place of many stories.

The wall can be read two ways, and neither is complete without the other. Read as data, it is fifteen thousand individual markings, catalogued and compared by style. Read as law, it is one story, whole, that was never lost.

[IMAGE — wide shot of the full Marra Wonga wall]

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For years, researchers catalogued the ten clusters along the wall as separate designs, made at different times by different hands, using different techniques — pecked, incised, rubbed smooth by hands that returned to the same lines more than once. Cross-referenced against each other, they read as unrelated. It was only when the clusters were walked in the order they actually sit on the rock, south to north, that the separate markings resolved into one continuous account.

[IMAGE — one cluster of engravings, close up]

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Read south to north, in sequence, the study confirmed what was already known: the ten clusters tell one story, the Seven Sisters.

The sisters pursued. The boomerangs thrown. The Rainbow Serpent. The dingo watching over the one who stayed on Earth. What the study identified as a structural discovery — a single narrative running the length of a rock art site, unmatched anywhere else in the world — was, in Iningai law, the story being told the way it has always been told: in order, one end of the wall to the other, the way a person walks it, the way it has to be walked to be understood at all.

IN ININGAI LAW

The wall is not a record of the past. It is a record of witnessing — proof kept in stone that someone was here, present, watching, for longer than almost anything else still

standing. It isn't a gallery and it was never finished. It is still being read, the same wall, the same order, generation after generation.

Law is carried in stages, the way anything worth knowing is carried. What's told here is what can be shared with anyone who comes to it with respect. There is more held in the wall than this — kept for those who go further into it, in their own time, on Country, the way it has always been passed down rather than published.

[IMAGE — the human footprint engravings with six toes]

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The Seven Sisters are the Pleiades. Their story is told in more than eighty places across this continent, and in cultures on the other side of the world — one of the oldest stories still being told anywhere on Earth, and one of the only constellations visible from both hemispheres.

Some of what's on the wall is common knowledge. Some is women's, and some is men's. What's written here is the part that is told away from Country.

The reading was published after a two-year study, carried out with Iningai people as full research partners rather than subjects providing access. It isn't the last word. A team of astrophysicists is coming next, to work out how the sequence on the wall lines up with the night sky above it — the same partnership, carried into its next chapter. Every study run on Marra Wonga so far has found more structure than the one before it, not less.

Read as data, the wall has never been scientifically dated. Based on regional style sequences, the pecked designs are likely more than 5,000 years old; mud wasp nests built over some of the engravings could eventually give a minimum age, if they are ever sampled. The escarpment itself is older again — compressed floor of an inland sea that once reached this far, with fossil footprints and petrified trees still in the rock beneath the engravings.

IN ININGAI LAW

Long before the current night sky took its shape, before the sea that once lay across this ground had fully withdrawn, this Country was already being watched, and already being marked. The wall reaches back further than any date a study has offered, or is likely to.

[IMAGE — a mud wasp nest built over part of an engraving]

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Two ways of reading the same stone. Neither one finished it first. Researchers will keep dating what can be dated. Law will keep being carried the way it has always been carried. Marra Wonga has never needed the two accounts to agree in order for both to be true.

Published as Marra Wonga: Archaeological and contemporary First Nations interpretations of one of central Queensland's largest rock art sites, *Australian Archaeology*, 2022.

doi.org/10.1080/03122417.2022.2084666